

The Best Places to Eat Paella

La Pepica moderate

Ernest Hemingway, Orson Welles, and their matador friends all heaped praises on La Pepica, where the menu features a modest eight rice dishes. These encompass all that is great about Valencian rice cookery, from the classic *paella valenciana* and the shellfish-topped *paella marinera* to the squid-and-its-ink *arroz negro*. The formality of the wait staff, smartly clad in white shirts and black waistcoats, heightens the sense of ceremony, especially when the paella is presented with a slight bow. The restaurant was established in 1898 on Playa Malvarossa and remains the principal temple of paella in the city that invented the dish. The front door is on the beach, but entering through the back from Paseo Neptuno gives customers a look behind the scenes at the voluminous kitchen of blue-and-white tiles and stainless-steel appliances where *paelleras* of every size dangle overhead.

2, 6, 8 Paseo Neptuno, Playa de la Malvarossa, Valencia; open for lunch Mon–Sun, dinner Mon–Sat; www.lapepica.com

Also in Valencia

At the edge of the old city, **Restaurante de Ana** (www.restaurantedeana.com; moderate) is a stickler about using exquisite fresh snails in its *paella valenciana*. Its *arroz estilo Albufera* is a paella with succulent duck. Traditional paella at the chic eatery of superchef Vicente Chust, **Restaurante Chust Godoy** (www.chustgodoy.com; expensive), is well worth the one-hour wait for its preparation.

Also in the Valencia Region

Literally across the road from rice fields in the Albufera, **La Matandeta** in Alfafar (www.lamatandeta.com; moderate; open Easter–Sep only) often prepares its sublime paellas in the outdoor courtyard during the summer months. The casual **El Pescador** (+34 965 842 571; inexpensive) in Altea creates excellent seafood paellas as well as grilled local fish. In Elche, **Els Capellans** (+34 966 610 011; moderate) is famed for its Alicante-style paella studded with meatballs and topped with fluffy egg.

Around the World

Many restaurants in the great Mexican fishing port of **Veracruz** (try **La Choca**) make a delicious New World seafood paella called *arroz a la tumbada*, seasoned with hot peppers and usually topped with clams, shrimp, conch, squid, and red snapper. In New York City, **Socarrat Paella Bar** (www.socarratpaellabar.com; moderate) serves five different kinds of paella, including the traditional *paella valenciana* and a vegetarian version, and waiters offer to help you scrape up the crunchy *socarrat* at the bottom of the *paellera*.



Above Many cooks today add smoked paprika to give their paella the earthy, smoky taste traditionally imparted by cooking over a wood fire

Left The secret to a great paella lies in the *sofrito*, a slow browning of meat and vegetables, before the rice is added to the *paellera*